

(Almost) No theory, Just a Task

A Regime Theory of Joy

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The Minimal Z-reduction Task

The aim is to enter a different regime of experience, a different brain configuration from the one most adults usually inhabit. It is normal for it to feel unfamiliar at first. If your reaction is, “This task is not for me,” that is actually predicted by the theory behind it.

What is expected is a threshold effect: nothing, nothing, nothing and then boom. So give it at least a few days.

Z?

Z is the weight of destiny: the sense that an experience carries evaluation or a next action.

High Z directs us toward more instrumental regimes, where attention is organized around evaluation. When Z falls, something can matter without requiring a response. More pleasant regimes become easier to enter.

In early childhood, joy is the baseline. Children probably barely notice it, and therefore never report it. In adults, it does not happen anymore, as learning naturally increases Z: one knows how the world is organized, and daily destiny weight is high.

What also changes in adulthood is that the next action is pressing forward. At school, there were genuine breaks: periods in which nothing further could be done. That was where joy could exist. The ease regime, supporting permissive features such as vivid imagination and joy, is blocked-out in part by the constant certainty that another precise action must follow.

Many behaviours increase Z. But the relation is reciprocal: once Z is elevated, it also increases the pull toward them.

Z = Weight of Destiny

The felt load of evaluation, consequence, and next-action pressure.

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Example: Choosing a Sidewalk

When we have to choose a sidewalk, a choice presents itself. We often select one side and treat it as the one that will somehow “carry us,” while the other is implicitly treated as the worse option. This gives one side a weight of destiny, a small story. Z rises.



Solution: Instead, one can think: “I have to choose a side, but the two sides remain equal in quality.” You still choose one, but the weight of destiny attached to that choice stays low: both sides remain mentally equal in importance.

However, here is the catch: if you do this at every street corner, it becomes “the technique for reducing Z.” Likewise, if you evaluate the task, “Did I successfully avoid comparing?”, the exercise itself then acquires a weight of destiny, and Z increases or remains unchanged rather than decreasing.

Therefore Z, tends to increase when one focuses, or the longer the exercise lasts. The exercise rapidly becomes something “dramatized”, therefore the weight of destiny increases. So, Z reduction exercises are made to be light, rare and short.

Two remarks.

#1 Very early in life, the weight of destiny is low by default. Picture a very young child among ordinary objects. They do not yet know what these objects are for and may encounter them mainly as shapes, colors, and textures. They cannot yet assign a function to keys or pens. As a result, nothing in the environment yet carries a weight of destiny: strong joy is their baseline.

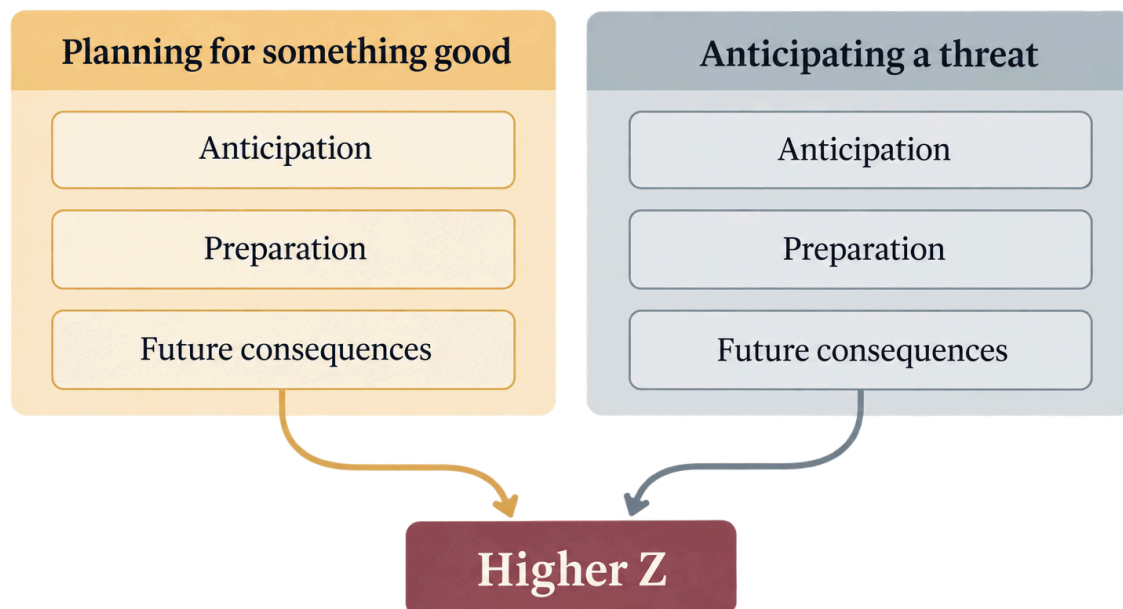
#2 Around the middle of secondary school, the weight of destiny rises. At first, this increase seems appealing: we are offered a somewhat interesting story, full of twists, in which we are the main character, a kind of hero, and every decision potentially leads somewhere. It is flattering, and the feeling of making progress is pleasant.

But we do not see the regime that grants access to rich experiences is slipping away.

The aim is not to eliminate instrumental functioning, but to restore flexible access to a non-instrumental regime. However, for a first transition, a significant drop of Z is required.

Positive and negative anticipation

Different feeling, similar future-oriented load



- *Good and bad anticipation/evaluation both increase the weight of destiny (Z).*

Objects

Seeing objects through their functions increases Z. When we enter a room, we notice equipment, and immediately assign it a use. The felt weight of destiny of the scene rises, and so does Z. For a brief moment, pause and refrain from choosing what to do next. After this brief moment, continue normally.

Pause Before Utility: After picking up an object, let it remain in your hand briefly before using it.

Several Objects Together: Briefly notice several objects together before one becomes the focus. “The” item is less charged in destiny if it is seen as “one among many” first.

The Present Moment

The idea that the present moment is all that exists, and therefore must be fully attended to, is deeply embedded in our culture. But treating the present as important increases Z.

One Among Many exercise offers a different stance: instead of treating the current moment as the only that counts, it is briefly lived as one insignificant moment among many.

Ex: A mouse click is simply one click among others. A selected book is only one among others. A webpage is only one among others. A street is only one among others.

Colors

Colors are rapidly integrated into object recognition and functional interpretation, helping identify what things are and what to do with them. Think of Christmas decorations, or street signs.

Let the Colors Stand Out: Briefly let the colors in the scene stand out without becoming signals for action.

Importance

Gold, for instance, is rare because its supply is limited, precious because it is useful for particular purposes, and expensive because its market price is high. Importance and preciousness are one way for the weight of destiny to rise.

Sometimes, notice an ordinary detail and label it as important.

Example: I am on the computer, enjoying a music video. I look at a nearby pen on the desk and I think “important”, I don’t have to focus on it (it would increase the weight of destiny), it is done lightly. Then I go *immediately back* to the computer. However, I don’t frame it as “I go immediately back”, as it would also increase the weight of destiny. I just do it, and I don’t check or verify after.

Preferences

Having a preferred time, place, or destination can lead to planning around it, and therefore high Z.

Thinking, “*It will be great there,*” increases Z by increasing anticipation, comparison, and the search for evidence as an additional mini-task. There are no specific exercises for this, so one may simply try to progressively stop.

Cinema, Series, News, books and YouTube.

Films and series constantly call for what comes next: unanswered questions and narrative continuation. News and YouTube use a similar mechanism through clickbait and the promise of further information. In both cases, Z rises.

Much of this content is designed for a high-Z audience. It offers rewards suited to an evaluative regime, but does not support joy. The possible exceptions are music videos and tableau-like films in which each scene can stand on its own, often older adventure films.

When Z is already high, or begins rising again, there is a stronger impulse to search for this continuation-driven content. Sunday evening is a familiar example: the desire to watch, search, and find out what happens next often returns.

One can try:

Meaning Left Open: Briefly let something be understood only partway, good for both videos and books,

Neutral Liking: Briefly watch a character without deciding whether you like or dislike them.

Background Character: For a brief moment, let a background character seem as important as the main character (good for music videos)

One Scene is Enough: Let one scene exist on its own without anticipating the next one.

Playlist Without a Center: Look at the entire folder as though no track in it is the center.

Another Artist: For one second, let a track seem as though it belonged to a different artist. Then continue.

Imagination

At times, you can refrain from extending your imagination by leaving unimagined what might be happening behind a door, beyond a window, or on the other side of an obstacle. Imagining (visual) scenarios is high Z, because it forms a narrative and to find reasons to have them in the first place.

No Event: Imagine a place where nothing happens; then let it fade.

Fading Image: Imagine an item, notice when it fades. Don't add another image to compensate.

Time and Priority

In adult life, time is treated as a foundation of maturity, destiny and seriousness.

Nothing Needs to Happen Next: For a brief moment, nothing needs to happen next.

Humour

Although humour may seem opposed to Z, it is not. Most humorous content revolves around politics or everyday observations, all of which recruit destiny-like feelings (“This is true, good observation!”). Even absurd humour is not necessarily low-Z: it usually requires following a narrative before the punchline arrives.

Humour can still be pleasant in a high-Z regime, and there is nothing wrong with that. But it is a form of pleasure that moves one away from joy.

Sacralization

Sacralization is close to the idea of the “present moment”: when something stands out as special, important, or meaningful, Z rises.

One possible exercise is to mentally equalize an object’s importance with what surrounds it. The same can apply to software options, browser tabs, and icons.

Another trick to reduce the “sacred” quality of *any* perception is:

What Appears, Appears: look at or open something. Briefly, there is nothing you need to feel. What appears, simply appears.

Don’t congratulate yourself. It feels good, but increases destiny-weight by sacralizing your current position.

Searching for Salience.

In everyday life, Z can rise quickly. One process that may maintain it is the search for salience, including a direct attempt to find joy.

This can involve repeatedly checking whether something is “there,” but also trying to provoke it visually, for example by looking at the sun or at nature because it is supposed to be beautiful.

Searching for salience raises Z because it quickly becomes a small quest: *Is this vivid enough? Is it working? Should I look longer?*

One could try looking at an *ordinary detail* instead. It decreases pleasure at first, and that is the point. Pleasure doesn't have to be a quest-like endeavor.

False Start: Briefly evoke the feeling of imminent significance. Let nothing need to happen. Then continue normally.

Weather

Weather often carries a quest-like endeavor. If the sun is here, it should be a good day, while if it rains, it is compromised.

Part of the Weather: Notice a part of the weather, and don't draw conclusions from it. "The sun", and continue.

Checking

"It is time to check" is Z high. The clearest example occurs when we lock the front door. We often go back to make sure that it is "properly locked."

Suppose I put a glass on a table. It may seem that no checking has taken place. But the automatic checks include: "Is this really a sensible place to put the glass?" or "Is it too close to the edge?"

At times, moving an object or looking at something only once, can lower Z, provided that it does not become a method, which would add verification to the non-verification itself and becomes a mini-quest again.

Alternative:

The Action Is Enough: Briefly let one small action be "enough". Then continue.

Vision

Don't always vision-focus. Briefly widen your visual field (peripheral vision) without searching for anything. Let the whole scene remain available if that is what your eyes want to see.

Agency

See your movements as "it happened" instead of being the author. It is useful because it reduces the quest-like feature of movement itself.

Category Softening

On the computer, briefly let a button seem a little less clearly to be "a button."

Let an icon seem not quite completely like an icon.

Open questions

In the media, especially the news, a process maintains destiny-like thinking: questions left open through clickbait. News headlines often avoid answering the subject directly. For example: "LIVE. White House meeting: the president will speak after meeting with

party leaders.” Reading this immediately raises quest-like questions such as “Why?”, “When?”, and “With whom?”, because the relevant information has been carefully withheld from the headline.

Most narrative entertainments also continuously let questions open, which is also called suspense. In both cases, Z is increased.

Title Without a Question: Sometimes, simply read a news title but don’t treat it as a question that needs an answer.

Question Without Answer: Think of a simple question. Do not search for an answer. Let the question fade.

Next Action

The core principle of quest-like thinking: what to do next? You can try some pauses directly aiming at this by:

Before the Next Action: Briefly let the next action remain undecided. Then continue normally.

Failed Quest Object: Look at an object as if it were a quest object in a game. Then abandon the quest immediately.

Useless Clue: An object becomes a clue. But the investigation never begins.

Social Life

Apart from local, purposeless playground games, social life tends to involve a considerable amount of destiny-like thinking. Consider a few simple situations: waiting for someone, having an appointment, searching for arguments, talking about oneself, or imagining other people’s reactions in order to prepare a better response.

Complete enough: In a light conversation context, you can say something once “as if it is complete enough.”

Recognition or Approval: Generate a feeling of recognition or approval. Normally, perceiving a character rapidly recruits evaluation, interpretation, or preparation for a social response - quest-like behaviors -. This exercise briefly generates a simple feeling of recognition, allowing it to exist without needing to analyze or act on it. The quest-like status of recognition is disrupted.

Hello for Nothing: Say "hello" without checking how it was received.

Don't justify yourself too much. If late, just say "sorry, I am late" and that's it.

Books

Starting a book, and searching for meaning, are quest-like, destiny-like behaviors. Instead:

Paragraph Fragments: Open a book at any page, and read some lines in an unordered fashion. If you happen to not understand the story, let the meaning open, instead of trying to understand it.

Ordinary Book: For a brief moment, regard a book as just another ordinary object.

Walking outside

Normally, walking is directed toward a goal: reaching a destination, exercising, or exploring. Occasionally, take one step that is slightly too long or too short, then return to your normal pace, so that the whole walk is not entirely directed toward a purpose.

Arrival Is Not Urgent: For a moment, the exact moment of arrival becomes less important.

Comparison

Normally, the environment rapidly recruits a preferred direction, preparing movement toward one option rather than another.

For a brief moment, neither side of the street seems preferable.

Equal Importance: For a brief moment, notice nearby objects equally. There is no need to choose which one deserves more attention.

Valuing Something, Including Pleasure

Two things matter here: avoid assigning special value to the state, and sometimes even interrupt it deliberately, for example by stopping a song just as you begin to enjoy it.

Thoughts such as “This has to continue” increase perceived value and evaluation, causing the peak to collapse rather than sustaining it.

Just an Mp4: Briefly see a video you like as simply an MP4 file.

Ordinary detail: Briefly notice one visual detail that is irrelevant to what you are doing.

Those 2 exercises will, at first, collapse joy or enjoyment, which is something that must be tolerated.

As a Conclusion: Within a Video Game (2-5 minutes)

Choose a video game, decrease its quest-like feeling:

- remove or ignore score
- don't try to win
- do suspension moves, for example changing direction for no reason, firing one time beside an enemy, switching weapon one time
- add any brief exercise you want, *keep them spaced* and the session short

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.

References

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. SSRN. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

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